Trading Under the AfCFTA – a Guide for Cameroon

Cameroon belongs to one Regional Economic Community (REC): the Economic Community of Central African States (ECCAS). Although not a REC, Cameroon also belongs to the Central African Economic and Monetary Union (CEMAC).

ECCAS

Angola, Burundi, Cameroon, the Central African Republic, Congo, Gabon, Equatorial Guinea, DRC, Rwanda, São Tomé and Príncipe and Chad

The **Central African Economic and Monetary Community (CEMAC)** is an **economic union** established in 1994 with the objective of furthering regional integration and policy effectiveness. It succeeds the Customs and Economic Union of Central African States (UDEAC), the initial framework for cooperation between six Central African states, founded by the Brazzaville Treaty of December 1964. The participating member states are Cameroon, Central African Republic (CAR), Chad, Congo, Equatorial Guinea and Gabon. CEMAC operates a common external tariff (CET) on imports from outside the bloc; a free trade area (the gradual removal of tariffs on intraregional trade was completed in 1998); a common currency (the CFA franc); and macroeconomic convergence mechanisms. The Treaty establishing CEMAC was revised in 2008. CEMAC countries all also belong to ECCAS; hence there are overlapping memberships and comparable mandates.

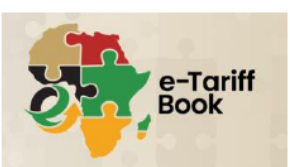
44 Non-ECCAS countries

The **Economic Community of Central African States (ECCAS)** was established on 18 October 1983 by the signing in Libreville of its Constitutive Treaty, which was revised and adopted on 18 December 2019. ECCAS is a grouping of the six CEMAC countries together with five additional member states: Angola, Burundi, the Democratic Republic of Congo, Rwanda, and São Tomé and Príncipe. ECCAS has adopted a legal framework for a **Customs Union** with **a common external tariff** for imports from outside countries. ECCAS is one of the eight RECs recognised by the African Union. The AfCFTA Agreement provides that REC FTAs are the building blocks of the AfCFTA.

Given that Cameroon is a participating member is ECCAS/CEMAC, preferential trade in goods will continue with ECCAS and CEMAC member states under the AfCFTA.

➡ **New preferential trade opportunities for Cameroon under the AfCFTA will be with *countries outside ECCAS* with whom Cameroon does not trade under any existing Free Trade Area or Customs Union rules.**

AfCFTA Operational instruments

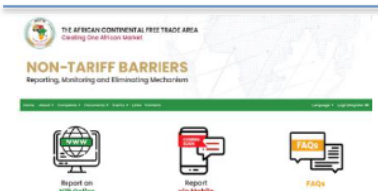


The *AfCFTA e-tariff book* is a digital platform containing the tariff schedules with applicable tariff rates for all AfCFTA State Parties based on the WCO 6-digit Harmonised System (HS). Goods are classified in three Categories: i) Category A – non sensitive products (90% of tariff lines), ii) Category B – sensitive products (7% of tariff lines), and iii) Category C – products that are excluded from liberalisation (3% of tariff lines).

http://etariff.au-afcfta.org/

RULES OF ORIGIN
MANUAL

The *AfCFTA Rules of Origin Manual* serves as a guide to the operationalisation of Annex 2 on Rules of Origin. It provides detailed information on how to determine the national origin of goods so that they can be traded between State Parties under the AfCFTA preferential tariff rates. https://au-afcfta.org/rules-of-origin/



The *AfCFTA Online Mechanism for Reporting, Monitoring and Elimination of NTBs* is a portal for online reporting of identified non-tariff barriers (NTBs), including for reporting via SMS. Reported NTBs and the status of their resolution can be tracked. https://tradebarriers.africa/

The *Pan-African Payment and Settlement System (PAPSS)*, developed by the African Export-Import Bank (Afreximbank) in collaboration with the African Union and AfCFTA Secretariat, is a cross-border payment and settlement infrastructure for transactions across Africa. PAPSS allows for payment and settlement using local currencies.

https://papss.com/

The AfCFTA Secretariat has partnered with AfroChampions, governments and industry to launch the *AfCFTA Hub* platform. The AfCFTA Hub aims to simplify AfCFTA rules for SMEs and startups, level the playing field in e-commerce & e-logistics so everyone can participate and benefit from the stated objectives of the AfCFTA and facilitate the integration of African economies.

https://hub.au-afcfta.org/

Cameroon's participation in the AfCFTA

Cameroon signed the AfCFTA Agreement on 21 March 2018, the date on which the Agreement was presented for signature in Kigali, Rwanda. The Agreement was ratified by Cameroon on 31 October 2019 and its instrument of ratification deposited on 1 December 2020.

Cameroon was among the first group of countries to participate in the Guided Trade Initiative, launched by the AfCFTA Secretariat in October 2022. The group of seven (7) initial participating countries included Egypt, Ghana, Kenya, Mauritius, Rwanda and Tanzania, with the later inclusion of Tunisia. In the prelude to the launch of the GTI, the Cameroon National Shippers' Council was mandated on 8 September 2022 to host the GTI Ad-hoc Sub-committee.

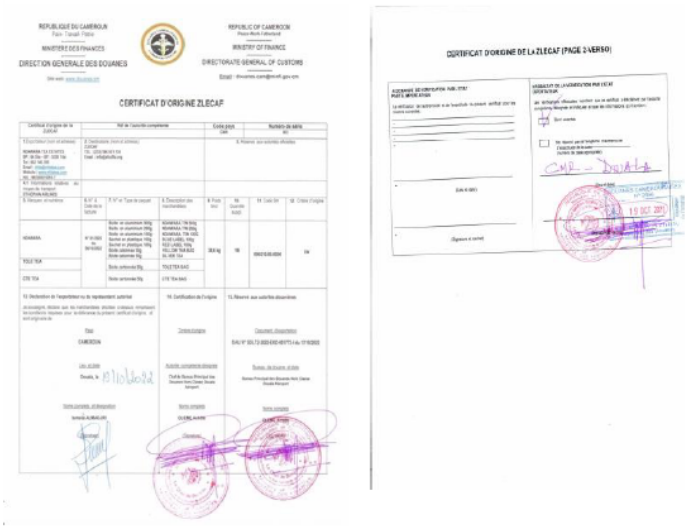
On 6 October 2022, the customs administration issued the first AfCFTA Certificate of Origin. GIC AFATEX received certification to **export** goods under AfCFTA rules, with the shipment of safou fruits, dried pineapples, and ginger tea to Ghana. On 19 October, two other Cameroonian agribusinesses, Cameroon Tea Estate and Ndawara Tea Estate, exported 38.6 kilograms of tea to Ghana under the same framework (see the image below). On 5 July 2024, the first containerised export to Algeria comprised of 99.4 tons of Aluminium ingots and produced by the Cameroonian Aluminium Company (Alucam) and was transported in four 20-foot containers.

Cameroon's first AfCFTA-supported **import** of goods consisted of a consignment of 20 TEU of Resin from Tunisia which arrived at the Kribi deep-sea port on 3 July 2023. This cargo was released from the container terminal on 17 July 2023.

Certificate of Origin

Responsibility for the issuance of certificates of origin lies with the Chamber of Commerce, Mines, Industries and Handicraft (CCIMA), the National Cocoa and Coffee Board (ONCC) for Cocoa and Coffee, the Banana Association of Cameroon (ASOBACAM), the National Hydrocarbon Corporation (SNH) for petroleum products, Ministry of Arts and Culture for artefacts, and the Ministry of Forestry and Wildlife for wood and animals. Cameroon has already taken steps by implementing the National Single Window (NSW) system, which enables businesses to submit all their customs documentation electronically.

AfCFTA certificate of origin issued by the Cameroonian Customs Office at Douala International Airport on 19 October 2022


REPUBLIQUE DU CAMEROUN
MINISTERE DES FINANCES
DIRECTION GENERALE DES DOUANES

REPUBLIC OF CAMEROON
MINISTRY OF FINANCE
DIRECTORATE GENERAL OF CUSTOMS

CERTIFICAT D'ORIGINE ZLECAF

CERTIFICAT D'ORIGINE DE LA ZLECAF (PAGE 2-VERSO)

A national AfCFTA Implementation Strategy for 2020-2035 has been published, which aims to be an essential tool for the operationalisation of the AfCFTA in Cameroon. An Inter-Ministerial Committee charged with the follow-up and evaluation of the implementation of the AfCFTA was signed on 29 March 2021. The Committee resides under the Minister of Trade and mandates it as a consultative organ responsible for research, elaboration, suggestions, and proposals to government on issues linked with the effective and efficient implementation of the AfCFTA Agreement and the mobilisation of funding required for its functioning.

The AfCFTA **Authorised Economic Operators** programme will build on national and regional programs (*acquis*), WTO Trade Facilitation Agreement, and World Customs Organisation Conventions and Programs. The specified criteria to qualify as an "Authorised Operator" under the AfCFTA shall be related to compliance, or the risk of non-compliance, with requirements specified in a State Party's laws, regulations, or procedures (Annex 4, Article 13(2)). State Parties are encouraged to develop Authorised Operator schemes based on international standards, where such standards exist, except when such standards would be an inappropriate or ineffective means for the fulfilment of the legitimate objectives of the AfCFTA (Annex 2, Appendix 1: Article 13(6)).

Cameroon operates an AEO programme launched in June 2020 by the Directorate General of Customs with the aim to authorise eligible businesses to clear their goods post removal from the ports of entry. Operators must apply to receive accreditation; acceptance by Customs is based on the volume of the company's business, financial position, regularity concerning importations, and Customs criminal records should these exist (number of false duties adjusted on Customs declarations made by the company, and frequency of these adjustments). Contracts are signed between companies and the Directorate General of Customs. Benefits include eligibility of at least 40% of the importer's operations to access the blue channel (port exit without Customs control), which may increase to 90% or be decreased based on performance. The CEMAC Customs Code also includes a **regional AEO programme since 2022 as provided by Regulation No 03/22-CEMAC-UEAC-010A-CM-38 establishing the status of Authorised Economic Operators and modalities for mutual recognition in the CEMAC zone**. All exports must be declared in detail in accordance with the provisions of the CEMAC Customs Code and national regulations. As in the case of imports, only economic operators with importer/exporter status are authorised to engage in an export activity.

© tralac, 2025